EDUC 3: Principles and Methods of Teaching

DESIGNING THE CURRICULUM AND INSTRUCTIONAL PLAN

Processes, Considerations, and Frameworks for Effective Instruction Delivery

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PART I. THE PROCESSES INVOLVED IN DESIGNING A CURRICULUM OR INSTRUCTIONAL PLAN

Curriculum design is not a single act but a sequence of interconnected decisions. The seven-step sequence presented here follows the logic associated with Hilda Taba (1962), who argued that curriculum should be built by teachers themselves, beginning from the actual needs of learners rather than from abstract objectives handed down by authorities. Taba's (1962) grassroots position is worth noting: she believed that those who teach the curriculum should be the ones who design it, because they alone see what learners actually need.

Although the steps are listed in order, they are cyclical in practice. What a teacher discovers during evaluation becomes the diagnostic information for the next cycle. A teacher who treats the list as a straight line, completed once and filed away, has missed the point of the model.

1. Diagnosis of Learners' Needs

Before deciding what to teach, the teacher must determine what learners already know, what they can already do, and where the gaps lie. Without this, planning becomes guesswork dressed up as preparation.

Formal diagnostic methods include pre-tests, diagnostic assessments, reading inventories, and standardized screening tools. These give comparable, recordable data.

Informal diagnostic methods include classroom observation, oral questioning, review of past outputs, conversations with learners, and consultation with previous teachers or parents. These often reveal what tests cannot.

Diagnosis extends beyond academic readiness. It includes learners' language profiles, cultural backgrounds, socio-economic circumstances, interests, health, and home situations, because these shape whether and how learning happens. A learner who has not eaten breakfast, or who speaks a different language at home, is not a learner with a motivation problem.

Skipping this step is the most common planning error, and it is a quiet one. The lesson still gets taught; it simply gets taught to an imagined class rather than the real one.

2. Formulation of Learning Objectives

Once needs are known, the teacher formulates what learners should be able to do by the end of instruction. Objectives are the anchor of the entire design; every subsequent decision, from content to assessment, must trace back to them.

Well-formulated objectives share several features. They are stated in terms of learner performance rather than teacher activity. They use observable, measurable verbs. They are attainable within the time available. They are relevant to the competency being developed. And they span the cognitive, affective, and psychomotor domains rather than remaining permanently at recall.

Weak: “To discuss the parts of speech.” This describes what the teacher will do, not what the learner will be able to do. It cannot be assessed, because nothing observable has been promised.

Strong: "Identify and use the eight parts of speech correctly in original sentences." This describes observable learner performance, names the condition, and implies its own assessment.

A useful discipline is to ask, for every objective written: what would I actually see or collect that would prove this happened? If the answer is unclear, the objective is not yet finished.

3. Selection of Learning Contents

Content is the subject matter that carries the objectives. Because there is always more content available than time to teach it, selection is fundamentally an act of exclusion. Established criteria guide the decision:

- **Validity.** The content is accurate, current, and genuinely aligned with the stated objectives.
- **Significance.** The content is essential to the discipline and contributes to the learner's development, rather than being merely interesting trivia.
- **Utility.** The content is useful to the learner's present or future life.
- **Learnability.** The content is within the learners' developmental and cognitive reach, arranged so it can actually be learned.
- **Interest.** The content connects to learners' curiosity and experience, which affects engagement and retention.
- **Feasibility.** The content can be taught within the available time, resources, and expertise.

Attempting to cover everything is not thoroughness; it is a decision to let learners master nothing. Coverage and learning are different outcomes, and they compete for the same minutes.

4. Organization of Learning Contents

Selected content must be arranged so that learning builds rather than accumulates. Common organizing principles include moving from simple to complex, from concrete to abstract, from known to unknown, and from near to far. Content may also be arranged chronologically, thematically, or by increasing procedural difficulty, depending on the subject.

Three structural ideas govern organization. Scope refers to the breadth and depth of content covered. Sequence refers to the order in which content is taken up. Continuity and spiral progression refer to revisiting the same concepts at increasing depth across grade levels, so that learning is reinforced and extended rather than encountered once and abandoned. Integration, meanwhile, refers to connecting content across subject areas so that learning is not compartmentalized.

5. Selection of Learning Experiences

Learning experiences are the activities through which learners engage the content. Tyler's (1949) classic criteria still apply: the experience must give learners the opportunity to practice the behavior in the objective, must be satisfying to the learner, must be within the learner's reach, and multiple experiences can serve the same objective, while a single experience can serve several objectives.

The most useful test is alignment to the verb. If the objective says "analyze," then listening to a lecture about analysis is not a sufficient learning experience, because at no point does the learner analyze anything. The learner must perform the verb during instruction, not only during the test.

6. Organization of Learning Activities

Activities must be sequenced within the lesson so the period flows purposefully rather than merely filling time. A typical structure moves through three phases:

- **Preparatory activities** activate prior knowledge and establish purpose: drills, review, advance organizers, thinking maps, and motivation.
- **Developmental activities** carry the main learning: presentation, guided practice, discussion, investigation, and collaborative work.

- **Closure activities** consolidate and check understanding: exit cards, three-two-one activities, gallery walks, summaries, and low-stakes quizzes.

Organization also involves decisions about grouping, transitions, pacing, and time allocation per segment. Poorly planned transitions are where most classroom time is lost, and where most classroom management problems begin.

7. Determination of What to Evaluate and the Means of Doing It

Finally, the teacher decides what evidence will demonstrate that learning occurred and how that evidence will be gathered. This step includes selecting assessment types, designing the tools, and setting the criteria.

- **Diagnostic assessment** precedes instruction and establishes readiness, closing the loop back to step one. Diagnostic assessment is conducted before instruction begins, such as at the start of the school year, the beginning of a quarter, or before introducing a new lesson or competency. In the DepEd Philippines context, its primary purpose is to determine learners' prior knowledge, existing skills, misconceptions, and readiness for new learning. The information gathered enables teachers to plan appropriate instructional strategies and provide necessary interventions. For example, before teaching a Grade 6 lesson on persuasive writing, a teacher may ask students to write a short opinion paragraph on a familiar topic to gauge their current writing abilities. Similarly, teachers may administer pre-tests, use KWL (Know–Want to Know–Learned) charts, facilitate brainstorming activities, create concept maps, or conduct oral questioning to assess learners' preparedness before formal instruction begins.
- **Formative assessment** occurs during instruction, is primarily for learning rather than of learning, and should inform immediate adjustment. Formative assessment takes place during instruction and serves as an ongoing process of monitoring learners' progress while competencies are being taught. Rather than assigning grades, its primary purpose is to provide timely feedback to both teachers and learners so that instruction can be adjusted to address learning gaps. In Philippine classrooms, formative assessment may include classroom recitations, seatwork, worksheets, group discussions, exit tickets, quizzes, observation checklists, peer assessment, self-assessment journals, and performance tasks completed throughout the lesson. For instance, after teaching students how to identify the main idea of a passage, a teacher may ask learners to complete an exit ticket summarizing the main idea. If many students struggle, the teacher can revisit the concept before proceeding to the next lesson. Thus, formative assessment supports learning by continuously informing instructional decisions and helping students improve their performance.
- **Summative assessment** occurs after instruction and certifies achievement against the objectives. Summative assessment is **conducted after instruction has been completed,** typically at the end of a lesson, unit, quarter, or grading period. Its purpose is to determine the extent to which learners have achieved the intended learning competencies and to provide evidence for grading and reporting academic achievement. Summative assessments include quarterly examinations, written tests, research projects, oral presentations, science investigations, portfolios, practical demonstrations, and other performance tasks. For example, after completing a unit on ecosystem conservation, Grade 6 learners may be required to develop and present an environmental advocacy campaign, which is evaluated using a rubric assessing scientific accuracy, organization, creativity, and communication skills. The results of summative assessment provide teachers, learners, and parents with an overall picture of learners' mastery of the prescribed competencies and guide decisions regarding future learning and instruction.

The governing rule is alignment. If the objective calls for creating, a multiple-choice test cannot assess it, no matter how well the items are written. Misaligned assessment does more than produce an inaccurate grade; it quietly teaches learners which level of thinking actually counts, and they will study accordingly.

PART II. CONSIDERATIONS IN DESIGNING A CURRICULUM OR PLAN

Learning is not one thing. When Benjamin Bloom's committee set out in 1956 to classify educational objectives, they identified three broad domains in which learning happens: the cognitive, the affective, and the psychomotor. A useful shorthand is head, heart, and hand. The cognitive domain is the head, concerned with knowledge and thinking. The affective domain is the heart, concerned with attitudes, values, and feelings. The psychomotor domain is the hand, concerned with physical skills and coordination.

These domains are not three separate learners; they are three dimensions of the same learner, and they overlap constantly. Learning to focus a microscope is a physical skill (hand), but it requires knowing what a clear image looks like (head) and the patience to keep adjusting (heart). The value of the framework is practical: a complete lesson deliberately plans for all three, while a weak lesson quietly plans for only the cognitive and hopes the rest takes care of itself. Because the cognitive domain is the easiest to test with a written quiz, it has dominated planning and assessment for decades, and the other two domains are the ones most often forgotten.

1. The Cognitive Domain (the Head)

The cognitive domain concerns knowledge and the development of intellectual skills. It is the domain treated in detail through the revised taxonomy of Anderson and Krathwohl (2001), who reorganized Bloom's original 1956 framework into six ascending levels: Remember, Understand, Apply, Analyze, Evaluate, and Create. The governing principle for teachers is that the verb chosen in a learning objective fixes the level of thinking demanded, and therefore the activities and assessments that are legitimate. Because this domain is covered fully in the main handout, it is only summarized here so that the three domains can be seen together.

Revised Bloom's Taxonomy of Educational Objectives

Benjamin Bloom's original 1956 taxonomy classified educational objectives into levels of increasing cognitive demand. In 2001, Anderson and Krathwohl (2001) revised it in three consequential ways. First, the categories were renamed from nouns into verbs, emphasizing that thinking is something learners do rather than something they possess. Second, the top two levels were reordered so that Create, rather than Evaluate, occupies the highest position, on the reasoning that generating something original demands more than judging something existing. Third, a knowledge dimension was added, distinguishing factual, conceptual, procedural, and metacognitive knowledge, which gives teachers a two-dimensional grid rather than a single ladder.

The taxonomy's practical value for teachers is direct: the verb chosen in an objective determines the level of thinking demanded, and therefore constrains what activities and assessments are legitimate. Writing “evaluate” and then giving a matching-type test is not a minor inconsistency; it is a broken promise.

The Six Cognitive Process Dimensions

1. **Remember.** Retrieving relevant knowledge from long-term memory. Verbs: define, list, recall, identify, name, state, recognize. Sample objective: List the five elements of a short story. Typical assessment: objective test items.
2. **Understand.** Constructing meaning from instructional messages, including interpreting, exemplifying, classifying, summarizing, inferring, comparing, and explaining. Verbs: explain, summarize, paraphrase, classify, compare, interpret. Sample objective: Explain in your own words the theme of the story. Typical assessment: short-answer or oral explanation.
3. **Apply.** Carrying out or using a procedure in a given situation, whether executing a familiar task or implementing one in an unfamiliar context. Verbs: use, demonstrate, solve, implement,

execute, carry out. Sample objective: Use the correct verb tense in writing five original sentences. Typical assessment: problem sets, procedural tasks.

4. **Analyze.** Breaking material into constituent parts and determining how the parts relate to one another and to an overall structure. Verbs: differentiate, organize, attribute, examine, deconstruct, compare and contrast. Sample objective: Analyze how the author's word choice affects the tone of the passage. Typical assessment: essays, structured analysis tasks.
5. **Evaluate.** Making judgments based on criteria and standards through checking and critiquing. Verbs: critique, justify, defend, appraise, judge, assess. Sample objective: Evaluate the strength of the writer's argument using given criteria. Typical assessment: critique papers, structured defenses.
6. **Create.** Putting elements together to form a coherent or functional whole, or reorganizing elements into a new pattern. Verbs: design, compose, construct, formulate, produce, generate, plan. Sample objective: Compose an original persuasive essay on a community issue. Typical assessment: performance tasks and products.

Two cautions are worth stating. First, the levels are not strictly hierarchical in practice; learners can create at simple levels and remember at sophisticated ones, and treating the taxonomy as a staircase that must be climbed in full before any higher-order work is permitted has kept many classes at the bottom indefinitely. Second, higher-order does not mean better in every instance. Foundational knowledge is genuinely necessary; the error is stopping there.

2. The Affective Domain (the Heart)

The affective domain concerns attitudes, values, emotions, interests, and the willingness to act. It was detailed by Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia (1964) in the second handbook of the taxonomy, which arranges affective learning into five ascending levels, from merely noticing that something exists to living consistently by a value. This is the domain that determines whether learning survives the examination: a learner who comes to value reading keeps reading long after the grade is posted, while a learner who only passed the test forgets it. It is also the domain that is hardest to measure, which is precisely why it is so often dropped from assessment and, in consequence, from teaching.

Level	What it means	Sample verbs
1. Receiving	Willing to notice and attend to something.	listen, ask, be aware of, tolerate
2. Responding	Willing to participate and react actively.	participate, comply, volunteer, enjoy
3. Valuing	Attaches worth to it; shows commitment.	value, justify, support, share, differentiate
4. Organization	Fits the value among other values into a system.	compare, prioritize, integrate, relate
5. Characterization	Acts consistently by the value; it defines the person.	act, display, influence, embody, revise

For the Filipino teacher, the affective domain is not foreign theory. It is the home of the DepEd core values, *Maka-Diyos*, *Makatao*, *Makakalikasan, and Makabansa*, and it is what the values integration line of every Daily Lesson Log is asking the teacher to plan. Assessment in this domain is usually formative and descriptive rather than graded, relying on observation over time, self-report, journals, and rating or Likert scales rather than on written tests.

3. The Psychomotor Domain (the Hand)

The psychomotor domain concerns physical skills, coordination, and the manipulation of tools and materials. Bloom's original committee named this domain but never developed it, so later educators supplied taxonomies of their own. The version most used in teacher education is Simpson's (1972), which describes seven ascending levels from first sensing what to do to inventing an entirely new movement. The domain is far broader than physical education: handwriting, oral reading fluency, keyboarding, drawing a diagram, handling laboratory equipment, and delivering a clear demonstration lesson are all psychomotor performances, assessed through precision, speed, and coordination.

Level	What it means	Sample verbs
1. Perception	Uses sensory cues to guide action.	detect, distinguish, observe, select
2. Set	Ready to act — mentally, physically, emotionally.	begin, prepare, show readiness
3. Guided Response	Imitates; learns by trial and error.	copy, follow, imitate, attempt
4. Mechanism	Performs with habitual confidence.	execute, complete, perform, assemble
5. Complex Overt Response	Performs skillfully, accurately, smoothly.	operate, demonstrate, coordinate
6. Adaptation	Modifies the skill to fit new situations.	adapt, adjust, revise, vary
7. Origination	Creates a new movement or technique.	design, compose, construct, originate

A simpler and very practical alternative is Dave's (1970) five-level taxonomy, Imitation, Manipulation, Precision, Articulation, and Naturalization, which many teachers find easier for writing skill objectives. Two further versions exist in Harrow (1972), organized by degree of coordination. Whichever taxonomy is used, psychomotor outcomes are assessed through performance tasks scored with rubrics or skills checklists, never through recall items — a point that connects directly to the KPUP framework and DepEd Order No. 8, s. 2015, where such outcomes fall under Performance rather than Written Work.

Why the Three Domains Matter Together

The framework earns its place when it is used as a planning check rather than memorized as trivia. A lesson on proper handwashing that only asks learners to identify the seven steps has planned for the head alone, and a child could pass it without ever washing their hands. Adding an affective objective (willingly washing hands before eating) and a psychomotor objective (demonstrating the steps correctly at the sink) completes the lesson, because it now teaches the child to know it, to care about it, and to do it. The most useful question a teacher can ask of any lesson is therefore threefold: what will learners know, what will they come to care about, and what will they be able to do? A plan that can answer only the first is a third of a plan.

If the processes describe the steps, the considerations describe the factors a teacher weighs at every step. They function as a standing checklist that keeps a plan honest and realistic.

1. Learner Characteristics

Plans must fit the learners' developmental stage, prior knowledge, language background, interests, readiness, and circumstances. This includes learners with disabilities, gifted and talented learners, learners from indigenous communities, and learners in difficult situations. Tomlinson's (2017) principle is instructive here: teachers can differentiate content, process, product, or learning environment in response to learner readiness, interest, and learning profile. A plan that ignores who the learners are is a plan for an imaginary class, and imaginary classes are always easier to teach.

2. Learning Objectives or Competencies

Objectives anchor the design. Every other element must trace back to them, and where objectives are vague, the entire plan drifts without anyone noticing until assessment reveals the confusion. Objectives should also be shared with learners, not kept as teacher documentation, since learners who know the target are better positioned to hit it.

3. Content or Subject Matter

Content must be accurate, essential, developmentally appropriate, and connected to the learners' world. The operative question is not only whether the content is correct, but whether it is worth the learners' limited time. Every topic included is a topic chosen over something else.

4. Teaching and Learning Strategies

Strategies must match both the objective and the learners. Higher-order objectives require strategies that demand higher-order engagement, and no amount of enthusiasm converts a lecture into an analysis task. Variety matters, but variety pursued for its own sake is not the goal; alignment is. The professional question is not “what activity would be fun?” but “what activity would require them to do the thing I am claiming to teach?”

5. Learning Resources and Environment

Plans must account for what actually exists: available textbooks, materials, technology, classroom space, class size, and the physical and psychological climate of the room. A plan requiring equipment the school does not own is not a plan but a wish. The environment also includes emotional safety, since learners who do not feel safe will not risk the errors that learning requires.

6. Assessment and Evaluation

Assessment must be planned from the beginning, not appended at the end. This is the central claim of backward design, discussed in Part III: teachers should identify desired results, then determine acceptable evidence, and only then plan learning experiences. Planning activities first and inventing the test afterward is the most common sequence in practice, and it is the reason so many tests fail to match what was actually taught.

7. Time and Pacing

Every plan lives inside a fixed period, quarter, and school year. Realistic pacing accounts for the time genuinely available, including interruptions, and resists the persistent temptation to overload a single session. Overloading is rarely ambition; more often it is a failure to decide what matters most.

8. Curriculum Standards and Educational Policies

Teachers do not plan in a vacuum. Plans must comply with national standards and institutional policies while still leaving room for professional judgment. Standards define the destination; they do not dictate every step of the route, and treating them as a script surrenders the teacher's professional role.

PART III. DESIGNING FOR EFFECTIVE INSTRUCTION DELIVERY

This part moves from process to design frameworks. The first section presents four foundational design principles that shape how plans are built. The remaining sections address the taxonomies, styles, and assessment frameworks that give planning its precision.

1. Constructive Alignment

Biggs and Tang's (2022) constructive alignment holds that intended learning outcomes, teaching and learning activities, and assessment tasks must all point at the same thing. The word constructive comes from constructivism, the premise that learners construct meaning through what they do; the word alignment comes from the design requirement that what they do must match what they are meant to learn and how they will be judged.

Its diagnostic power lies in exposing misalignment. If the outcome says “design,” the activities say “listen and take notes,” and the assessment says “identify from a list,” then three different subjects are being taught in the same room. Biggs (2022) notes that learners are shrewd: when activities and assessment disagree with stated outcomes, learners follow the assessment. Alignment is therefore not a paperwork nicety but the mechanism by which stated intentions become actual learning.

2. Universal Design for Learning (UDL)

UDL, developed by CAST (2024), begins from the premise that learner variability is the norm rather than the exception, and that barriers reside in the design of instruction rather than in the learner. Rather than retrofitting accommodations after a lesson excludes someone, UDL designs flexibility in from the start. The framework's stated goal, in the 2024 Guidelines 3.0 update, is learner agency: learners who are purposeful and reflective, resourceful and authentic, strategic and action-oriented.

UDL is built on three principles, each with supporting guidelines:

- **Multiple means of engagement (the why of learning).** Guidelines cover welcoming interests and identities, sustaining effort and persistence, and emotional capacity. Practical considerations include optimizing choice and autonomy, optimizing relevance and authenticity, nurturing joy and play, fostering collaboration and belonging, offering action-oriented feedback, and promoting reflection.
- **Multiple means of representation (the what of learning).** Guidelines cover perception, language and symbols, and building knowledge. Practical considerations include customizing the display of information, supporting multiple ways to perceive information, clarifying vocabulary and symbols, cultivating respect across languages and dialects, illustrating through multiple media, connecting prior knowledge to new learning, and maximizing transfer and generalization.
- **Multiple means of action and expression (the how of learning).** Guidelines cover interaction, expression and communication, and strategy development. Practical considerations include varying methods for response and movement, optimizing access to accessible and assistive tools, using multiple media and tools for communication, building fluency with graduated support, setting meaningful goals, organizing information, and monitoring progress.

3. Teaching Styles

Teaching style refers to the approach a teacher habitually uses to deliver instruction. No single style is superior in all circumstances; the professional skill lies in matching style to objective, content, and learners, and in having enough range to make the match. A teacher with one style will teach every objective as though it were the objective that style suits.

Major Teaching Styles

1. **Lecture or Direct Instruction.** The teacher explicitly presents information in a structured, teacher-directed sequence, typically moving from stated objective to modeling to guided practice to independent practice. Best for introducing new content efficiently, clarifying difficult or misconception-prone concepts, and building foundational knowledge quickly. Strength: efficient and clear. Risk: learner passivity if used exclusively, and the illusion that having said something is the same as having taught it.
2. **Demonstration.** The teacher performs a process or skill while learners observe, followed by guided practice and feedback. Best for procedural knowledge, laboratory work, and any skill that must be seen to be understood. Strength: makes tacit procedures visible. Risk: learners watch without ever performing, if practice is cut for time.
3. **Facilitative or Student-Centered Teaching.** The teacher guides rather than tells, prompting learners to construct understanding through discussion, questioning, and discovery. Best for

developing independence, reasoning, and deep understanding. Strength: builds durable learning and learner agency. Risk: requires skilled questioning and more time, and can drift into unguided discussion that confirms misconceptions.

4. **Inquiry-Based Teaching.** Learning begins with a question, problem, or phenomenon, and learners investigate to construct understanding. Commonly structured through the 5E model (Engage, Explore, Explain, Elaborate, Evaluate) or the 7E extension (adding Elicit and Extend). Best for developing scientific thinking, curiosity, and evidence-based reasoning. Risk: needs careful scaffolding, since inquiry without guidance frequently produces confident error.
5. **Cooperative Learning.** Learners work in structured small groups characterized by positive interdependence, individual accountability, face-to-face interaction, social skills, and group processing. Best for developing social competence and peer learning. Strength: multiplies engagement without multiplying materials. Risk: without individual accountability, it degenerates into group work where one learner does everything.
6. **Project-Based Learning.** Learners engage in an extended, meaningful project culminating in an authentic product, typically driven by a real question and an audience beyond the teacher. Best for integrating multiple competencies and connecting school to life. Risk: time-intensive, and can produce impressive products that conceal thin learning if assessment targets the artifact rather than the understanding.
7. **Differentiated Instruction.** The teacher proactively varies content, process, product, or learning environment in response to learners' readiness, interest, and learning profile. Best for classes with wide ranges of readiness and ability, which describes most classrooms honestly examined. Tomlinson's (2017) key distinction: differentiation is proactive design, not reactive rescue after a learner fails.

4. Learning Styles

Learning style refers to the preferred way a learner takes in and processes information. The most widely used framework in teacher education is the VARK model developed by Neil Fleming, which identifies four modal preferences.

The VARK Model

1. **Visual.** Preference for information presented through diagrams, charts, maps, graphic organizers, and symbolic representation. Note that in Fleming's (2006) formulation, Visual refers to symbolic and diagrammatic representation rather than to pictures generally. Teaching response: concept maps, flowcharts, colour coding, illustrated timelines.
2. **Aural or Auditory.** Preference for information that is heard or spoken, including discussion, lectures, oral explanation, and talking things through. Teaching response: discussion, oral questioning, read-alouds, verbal summaries, peer explanation.
3. **Read/Write.** Preference for information displayed as words: texts, lists, notes, definitions, and written handouts. Teaching response: readings, note-taking, written summaries, glossaries.
4. **Kinesthetic.** Preference for learning through experience and practice, whether simulated or real, including movement and hands-on work. Teaching response: manipulatives, role play, simulations, fieldwork, practical tasks.

Fleming (2006) also notes that many learners are multimodal, preferring several channels rather than one, which complicates any attempt to sort a class into four boxes.

Caution on Learning Styles

The evidence does not support the strong version of the learning styles claim, sometimes called the meshing hypothesis, which holds that matching instruction to a learner's preferred modality improves achievement. Controlled studies have repeatedly failed to find this effect, and Fleming (2006) himself, writing with Baume, argued that VARK is best understood as a reflective tool for starting conversations about learning rather than as a diagnostic instrument for labelling learners.

The defensible use is therefore not to identify each learner's channel and teach them separately. It is to present important content in multiple modes, because multimodal presentation benefits nearly everyone and because content itself has modal demands. Teaching learners to read a map requires visual work regardless of anyone's preference.

This distinction matters professionally. A teacher who says “he is a kinesthetic learner, so he struggles with reading” has explained nothing and excused a great deal. Understanding that learners differ is sound; assuming each learner has one fixed channel that must be matched is not, and it can quietly lower expectations.

5. Assessing Levels of Learning Outcomes: The KPUP Framework (DepEd, 2012, 2015)

The KPUP framework classifies learning outcomes into four ascending levels: Knowledge, Process, Understanding, and Performance. It was widely used in Philippine basic education to ensure that assessment reaches beyond recall toward authentic application. Even where terminology has since evolved, its underlying logic remains sound: learning should progress from knowing, to doing, to understanding deeply, to performing authentically, and assessment should follow it up that ladder rather than camping at the bottom.

A. Knowledge (K)

Definition. The substantive content learners acquire: facts, concepts, terms, principles, and information that form the foundation for all higher learning.

Indicators. Learners can recall, identify, name, define, state, and recognize information accurately. The evidence is retrieval.

Sample learning outcomes. Identify the eight parts of speech. Define the elements of a short story. State the rules of subject-verb agreement.

Caution. Knowledge is necessary and insufficient. Learners cannot analyze what they do not know, but knowing is not the destination.

B. Process (P)

Definition. The cognitive and procedural skills learners use in working with knowledge; what they can do with what they know.

Application of knowledge and skills. Learners organize, classify, compute, compare, investigate, sequence, and apply procedures. Knowledge is set in motion here.

Sample learning outcomes. Classify sentences according to structure. Organize ideas using a graphic organizer. Compare two characters using a Venn diagram. Sequence the events of a narrative.

C. Understanding (U)

Definition. Enduring big ideas and principles that learners internalize and can transfer to new and unfamiliar situations. This is where Wiggins and McTighe's (2005) distinction between knowing and understanding becomes operational.

Demonstrating conceptual understanding. Learners explain in their own words, justify with evidence, interpret, infer, draw conclusions, and apply concepts to situations never encountered in class. The test of understanding is transfer, not repetition.

Sample learning outcomes. Explain why word choice affects the tone of a text. Justify an interpretation of a poem using textual evidence. Draw conclusions about the author's purpose from an unfamiliar passage.

D. Performance (P)

Definition. The authentic application of learning, in which learners produce evidence of mastery through real or realistic tasks addressed to a genuine purpose or audience.

Authentic application of learning. Learners create products or perform tasks resembling what people actually do outside school, judged against criteria known in advance. Authenticity lies in the realism of the task and the standard, not in the elaborateness of the output.

Sample learning outcomes. Deliver a persuasive speech on a community issue before an audience. Write and publish a feature article for the school paper. Produce a video advocacy campaign on a local concern.

However, on June 4, 2026, the Department of Education signed DepEd Order No. 015, s. 2026, the Revised Guidelines on Classroom Assessment, Grading System, and Awards and Recognition for the K to 12 Basic Education Program. Effective School Year 2026-2027, it supersedes DepEd Order No. 8, s. 2015 on classroom assessment and DepEd Order No. 36, s. 2016 on awards. It is anchored on Republic Act No. 10533 (the Enhanced Basic Education Act of 2013) and aligned with the Revised Kindergarten to Grade 10 Curriculum and the Strengthened Senior High School Curriculum. For students of this course, the most important consequence is direct: the KPUP framework (Knowledge, Process, Understanding, Performance) is no longer in force.

What Was Repealed, and What Replaced It (DepEd, 2026)

Under the old DepEd Order No. 8, s. 2015, classroom assessment was often taught through KPUP, a four-level classification of learning outcomes, alongside three grading components (Written Work, Performance Tasks, and Quarterly Assessment) distributed across four quarters. The new order changes both the language and the structure. It does not grade by KPUP levels at all. Instead, grades in the numerical Key Stages are computed from three summative components, and the school year now runs on a three-term calendar rather than four quarters.

Component	Full name	What it measures
WWs	Written or Oral Works	Summative tasks needing written or spoken responses: essays, journals, written reports, structured presentations.
PTs	Product or Performance Tasks	Application of knowledge and skills in authentic contexts: projects, portfolios, investigations, performances.
EXs	Examinations	Two Summative Tests within the term plus one Term Examination at the end of the term.

Four Key Stages, Graded Differently

The single largest change is that grading is no longer one system for all learners. The approach now depends on the learner's Key Stage.

Key Stage	Grades	Grading approach
KS1	K – 3	Descriptive and non-numeric. Letter descriptors with narrative feedback; no numerical grade and no academic ranking. Phased in from Grade 1 (SY 2026-2027) to full K-3 by SY 2028-2029.
KS2	4 – 6	Numerical. Three components with prescribed weights; adjusted transmutation table this school year.
KS3	7 – 10	Numerical. Same components; GMRC and Values Education additionally graded across three domains.
KS4	11 – 12	Numerical. Senior High School weights vary by track and subject group.

For Key Stage 1, the order replaces numbers with descriptors such as *Advancing, Benchmarking, Connecting, Developing, and Emerging* (Grades 1-3), and *Consistent, Developing, and Beginning* (Kindergarten), each paired with narrative feedback on what the learner can do and what support comes next. The stated rationale is to avoid early competition and labeling and to focus on foundational literacy, numeracy, and socio-emotional development. No academic awards are given in Key Stage 1.

Component Weights (Grades 4 to 10)

For the numerical Key Stages, the order prescribes weights that deliberately give Product or Performance Tasks the largest share, signaling that authentic performance, not testing, is the primary evidence of learning.

Learning Area	WWs	PTs	EXs
English, Filipino, Math, Science, AP, GMRC / Values Education	20%	50%	30%
EPP / TLE and MAPEH	20%	60%	20%

Within the Examinations component, the two Summative Tests and the Term Examination are distributed as Summative Test 1 (30%), Summative Test 2 (30%), and Term Examination (40%). Senior High School weights differ by track: several subject groups place 60 to 80 percent on Product or Performance Tasks, and some (such as Work Immersion and Research electives) have no Examinations component at all.

Values Graded on Three Domains

For Good Manners and Right Conduct (Key Stage 2) and Values Education (Key Stage 3), the order requires grading across the Cognitive, Affective, and Behavioral domains — knowing the value, valuing it, and acting on it consistently. The Behavioral domain carries the largest share (30 percent, through Performance Tasks), because conduct observed over time is the truest evidence. This connects directly to the three domains of learning: the affective and behavioral dimensions, once merely “integrated” into a lesson, are now formally assessed. Teachers are expected to rely on observation over time and rubric-based evidence rather than one-time judgments, and such assessment is developmental rather than punitive.

How Grades Are Computed, and the Move to Zero-Based Grading

Grades are built in a clear chain: raw scores become percentage scores, percentage scores are multiplied by component weights to give weighted scores, and the weighted scores are added to produce the Initial Grade (IG). For School Year 2026-2027 only, an adjusted transmutation table converts the Initial Grade into the Term Grade (TG), where an Initial Grade of 70 maps to a passing 75 and the minimum reportable grade is 60. The average of term grades gives the Final Grade (FG), and the average of final grades across learning areas gives the General Average (GA). A Final Grade of 75 or higher is passing.

Beginning School Year 2027-2028, the order shifts to zero-based grading, which removes the transmutation table entirely: the computed grade is the grade reflected on the report card, with a default minimum of 60. The stated purpose is to end grade inflation from transmutation and to make reported grades reflect actual performance. Numerical grades must also be paired with qualitative descriptors (Advancing, Benchmarking, Connecting, Developing, Emerging) so a grade communicates proficiency, not just a number.

6. Assessment Tools for Each Level of Learning Outcomes

Assessment tools must match the level of the outcome. Using the wrong tool does not merely produce an inaccurate grade; it signals to learners which level of thinking actually counts, and they will allocate their effort accordingly. Assessment is the most honest statement of a teacher's priorities, whatever the lesson plan says.

Tools for Knowledge-Level Outcomes

- Objective tests: multiple choice, true or false, matching type, identification, and completion or fill-in-the-blank.
- Strength: efficient, objective, and scalable across large classes; broad content sampling in little time.
- Limitation: cannot reveal whether learners can use what they recall. Well-written multiple-choice items can reach Understand and Apply, but reaching Analyze and above is difficult and reaching Create is impossible.

Tools for Process-Level Outcomes

- Short-answer items, problem sets, graphic organizers, concept maps, structured worksheets, and data-interpretation tasks.
- Procedural checklists and observation guides that record whether steps were performed correctly and in order.
- Strength: makes the learner's process visible, not only the answer, which allows targeted remediation.

Tools for Understanding-Level Outcomes

- Essays, both restricted-response and extended-response, which reveal reasoning rather than retrieval.
- Open-ended questions, reflection papers, learning journals, and oral explanations or defenses.
- Transfer tasks that place a familiar concept in a genuinely unfamiliar situation, since transfer is the operational test of understanding.
- Strength: distinguishes learners who grasp the idea from those who have memorized the teacher's phrasing.

Tools for Performance-Level Outcomes

- Performance tasks: speeches, demonstrations, role plays, presentations, experiments, simulations, and debates.
- Products: essays, portfolios, videos, models, campaigns, research outputs, and creative works.
- Scoring instruments: analytic rubrics (separate criteria scored individually, useful for feedback), holistic rubrics (one overall judgment, faster for large classes), rating scales, and checklists.
- Strength: assesses integrated competence under realistic conditions. Requirement: criteria must be explicit and shared with learners beforehand, or the assessment becomes a guessing game about the teacher's taste.

Principles Governing Tool Selection

- **Alignment.** The tool must measure the verb in the objective. This is the first question, not the last.
- **Validity.** It measures what it claims to measure, and the inferences drawn from scores are defensible.
- **Reliability.** It yields consistent results across raters, items, and occasions. Rubrics exist largely to protect reliability in judgment-based scoring.
- **Fairness.** It does not disadvantage learners for reasons unrelated to the competency, such as language demands irrelevant to the outcome or resources not all learners possess.
- **Practicality.** It can be administered, scored, and returned within real constraints. An assessment that cannot be marked in time provides no feedback and therefore no learning.

In sum, designing a curriculum or instructional plan is a professional act of judgment, not a clerical task. The seven processes give the teacher a sequence: diagnose learners, formulate objectives, select and organize content, select and organize experiences, and determine how learning will be evaluated. The eight considerations keep that sequence grounded in the realities of learners, resources, time, and policy. The frameworks give it precision: OBE insists on demonstrated outcomes; backward design and constructive alignment insist that outcomes, activities, and assessment agree with one another; UDL designs out barriers from the start, Bloom's revised taxonomy calibrates cognitive demand, and KPUP with its matching tools keeps assessment honest to the level claimed.

What unites these frameworks is a single conviction: that teaching should be designed rather than improvised, and that the design should be answerable to what learners can actually do afterward. Every one of them, in its own vocabulary, resists the same two failures: teaching that is busy without being purposeful, and teaching that covers without reaching.

In Philippine public schools, all of this happens under real pressure: large classes, limited materials, multilingual learners, curricular reform, and administrative loads that compete with the very planning time the work requires. These constraints do not excuse weak planning. They make deliberate planning more necessary, because where resources are scarce, design is the resource that remains. A teacher who plans with honest diagnosis, clear objectives, aligned assessment, deliberate inclusion, and realistic pacing is doing the most consequential work available to them, and doing it where it matters most.

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